

# The Tell Afis Fragment and the Tel Dan Stele

## Comparative Epigraphic and Material Evidence for a Possible Common Origin

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### Abstract

This study examines the possibility that the Aramaic basalt fragment discovered at Tell Afis (TA.03.A.300) may belong to the same monumental inscription as the Tel Dan Stele (KAI 310). The analysis combines comparative epigraphy, paleography, material observations, fracture-profile considerations, and semantic reconstruction in order to evaluate possible convergences between the two corpora.

Both inscriptions share several notable characteristics: basaltic support, polished surface treatment, comparable glyphic morphology, Old Aramaic script, and the royal anthroponym Hazael (HZ'L). The study further emphasizes a major structural anomaly within the Tel Dan corpus: the absence of the presumed author's name in all currently assembled fragments. The Tell Afis fragment may provide a possible solution to this lacuna.

Recent RTI-based reassessments by Michael Langlois (2024), questioning the traditional reconstruction proposed by Biran and Naveh, reopen the spatial organization of the Tel Dan fragments and strengthen the legitimacy of considering additional fragmentary candidates.

Although no definitive attribution can presently be established, the convergence of epigraphic, material, and semantic indicators justifies further investigation through petrographic analysis, RTI comparison, and 3D fracture-profile matching.

### Keywords

Tell Afis; Tel Dan Stele; KAI 310; Aramaic inscription; Semitic epigraphy; Aramaic paleography; basalt stele; Hazael; comparative epigraphy; fracture-profile analysis; RTI imaging; Levantine archaeology; Northwest Semitic inscriptions; epigraphic reconstruction

## 1. Introduction and Background

The Tel Dan Stele is one of the most debated Aramaic inscriptions in the Near Eastern epigraphic corpus. Discovered in 1993 and 1994 at the site of Tel Dan (northern Israel) by Avraham Biran's team, it consists of three black basalt fragments (A, B1, B2) that reconstruct only a fraction of the original inscription. The object, shattered in antiquity, was apparently reused as building material in an eighth-century BCE wall. The preserved text — thirteen partial lines — refers to a military victory over the kings of Israel and the 'House of David', and is generally attributed to Hazael, king of Aram-Damascus. Central paradox: the name Hazael appears nowhere in the inscription.

The Aramaic fragment from Tell Afis (TA.03.A.300) was discovered in 2003 during excavations of the Mission of the Universities of Rome and Florence at Tell Afis (Idlib governorate, northern Syria), a site identified with ancient Hazrak (Hatarikka under the Neo-Assyrians), under the direction of Stefania Mazzoni. The fragment was reused in the pavement of the southern area of Temple AI on the acropolis (area A1). Published by Maria Giulia Amadasi Guzzo in the journal *Orientalia* in 2009 (inv. TA.03.A.300; drawing: Amadasi Guzzo and A. De Bonis), this basalt fragment measuring 24 cm (h.) × 7.8 cm (w.) × 5.2 cm (th.), with letter heights ranging from 1.2 cm (zayin, l. 5') to 2.8 cm (aleph, l. 2'), bears seven partial lines of an Aramaic inscription in which line 5' contains the anthroponym HZ'L (Hazael) and line 7' the lexeme MLK (king).

It is the simultaneous observation of several common characteristics that motivated the present study: same lithic material (basalt), same surface condition (polished), comparable glyphic style, and above all the mention of the same royal anthroponym in two corpora that structurally complement each other — one having the text without the author's name, the other having the name without the developed text.

## 2. Postulate and Methodological Framework

*If two epigraphic fragments share the same material, the same surface treatment, the same glyphic style and the same royal anthroponym, and if one structurally fills the documented lacunae of the other, the hypothesis of a common origin deserves to be systematically evaluated, independently of the geographical distance between their respective findspots.*

The comparison is conducted at three distinct levels, in increasing order of probative constraint:

- Physical and material level: material, surface condition, dimensions, fracture profiles
- Philological level: glyphic style, letter morphology, interlinear spacing
- Semantic level: complementarity of textual content, narrative coherence

## 3. The Aramaic Fragment from Tell Afis TA.03.A.300 — Primary Description

### 3.1 Archaeological Context of Discovery

*“A basalt stele fragment bearing an Aramaic inscription (inv. TA.03.A.300) was found during excavations of the Mission of the Universities of Rome and Florence at Tell Afis, corresponding to the ancient center of Hazrak. The fragment was reused in 2003 in the pavement of the southern area of Temple AI on the acropolis (area A1). It measures 24 cm in height, 7.8 cm in width, and 5.2 cm in thickness; the letters range from 1.2 cm (zayin of line 5') to 2.8 cm (aleph of line 2').” — Amadasi Guzzo, *Orientalia* 78 (2009), p. 336.*

The site of Tell Afis corresponds to ancient Ḥazrak (Hatarikka under the Neo-Assyrians), capital of the kingdom of Hamath and Lu'ash, identified through the Zakkur stele (KAI 202) found at the same site in 1903 by Henri Pognon. The Mission of the Universities of Rome and Florence, under the direction of Stefania Mazzoni, conducted excavations there from 1986 to 2010. The discovery context — reuse in a temple pavement — is directly comparable to that of the Tel Dan fragments, which were also found in a secondary position within a construction wall.

### 3.2 Transcription and Analysis of the Seven Preserved Lines

The preserved inscription comprises seven partial lines, lacunary on both sides. We reproduce here Amadasi Guzzo's transcription with notation of illegible signs (?) and uncertain readings (¹):

| Lig ne | Transcription (Amadasi Guzzo) | Lecture                             | Commentaire                                                                                                            |
|--------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1'     | ] '[                          | Single letter, undetermined context | Single letter, undetermined context                                                                                    |
| 2'     | ] (?)¹ ' (?) [                | Alef + illisibles                   | Aleph = 2.8 cm — maximum height. Heavily lacunary line.                                                                |
| 3'     | ] Q¹ D/R [                    | Qof + Dalet ou Resh                 | Uncertain reading (¹). Possible root QDR.                                                                              |
| 4'     | ] Š¹ L KL [                   | Tsade-Lamed + Kaf-Lamed             | Uncertain reading. ŠL (protection?) + KL (all?).                                                                       |
| 5'     | ] LHZ' ¹ L [                  | HZ' L = Hazael                      | KEY LINE — Zayin = 1.2 cm (smallest letter). ¹ = one sign with slightly uncertain reading. Attested royal anthroponym. |
| 6'     | ] YHW (?) [                   | YHW — theonym/PN                    | (?) = illegible sign. Yahwistic theophoric element or beginning of anthroponym.                                        |
| 7'     | ] MLK [                       | MLK = king                          | KEY LINE — In combination with HZ' L (l.5'): Hazael king.                                                              |

Table 1 — Transcription of fragment TA.03.A.300 after Amadasi Guzzo (2009). Orange lines = key elements for the hypothesis.

## 4. The Tel Dan Puzzle — An Open Reconstruction Problem

Before any comparison with Tell Afis, it is essential to recall that the internal reconstruction of the Tel Dan Stele is itself an unresolved problem. This fact, often minimized in the secondary literature, is central to our approach.

### 4.1 Biran and Naveh's Admission

The editors themselves admitted in 1995: “Fragments A and B cannot be joined in an obvious and unambiguous manner” (Biran & Naveh, IEJ 45, 1995, p. 11). This statement, buried in a footnote, is of considerable significance: it means that the lateral placement of B to the left of A — the basis of all subsequent reconstructions — is a working hypothesis, not a physical certainty.

### 4.2 Alternative Reconstructions

Several reconstructions of the relative placement of A and B coexist in the literature:

- Biran & Naveh (1993/1995): B to the left of A, lateral — standard reconstruction
- Schniedewind (1996): minor adjustments to the standard lateral placement
- Galil: B above A, vertical stacking
- Athas (2003): B well below A, vertical stacking — based on differing chisel angles between A and B1/B2
- Staszak (2009): B derives from the lower edge, A from the upper edge of the stele — two different scribes

4.3 Langlois’s Conclusion (RTI, IEJ 74/2, 2024)

In 2024, Michael Langlois (University of Strasbourg) applied Reflectance Transformation Imaging (RTI) to all the fragments. His conclusions are unambiguous:

- Fragment A presents a bet (ב) formed of two straight strokes — scribe 1
- Fragments B1 and B2 present a curved bet — scribe 2
- *“The placement suggested by the editors must be abandoned: fragment B does not continue the lines begun by fragment A” (Langlois, IEJ 74/2, 2024)*

This conclusion reopens the entire spatial reconstruction. The Tel Dan puzzle now has three mobile pieces whose exact topographical relationships remain open. It is in this context that a fourth piece — the Tell Afis fragment — may be proposed as a candidate for integration.

5. Physical and Material Convergences

5.1 Comparative Table

| Characteristic       | Tel Dan Stele (A+B)                | Fragment Tell Afis                |
|----------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Material             | Black basalt                       | Basalt                            |
| Surface condition    | Polished (inscribed face)          | Polished (inscribed face)         |
| Preserved dimensions | A : ~32×22×28 cm · B : ~20×25 cm   | 24×7,8×5 cm                       |
| Discovery context    | Secondary reuse (wall)             | Secondary reuse (temple debris)   |
| Language / script    | Old Aramaic / Phoenician alphabet  | Old Aramaic / Phoenician alphabet |
| Anthroponym Hazael   | Absent — inferred only             | Attested HZ’L (l.5’) + MLK (l.7’) |
| Documented scribes   | 2 distinct scribes (Langlois 2024) | Not analyzed                      |

Table 3 — Comparison of physical characteristics.

5.2 Fracture Profiles — Analytical Gap

The comparison of fracture profiles constitutes the decisive mechanical argument but is not yet available. If the fracture edges physically interlock and if the glyphs align on either side of the fracture, the proof of common membership is direct and sufficient — this is exactly the method used by Biran and Naveh to establish that B1 and B2 belong to the same object. At this stage, we work solely from published epigraphic drawings, whose precision is insufficient to conclude on mechanical interlocking. Furthermore, no geochemical provenance analysis of the Tel Dan basalt has been published to date — a remarkable gap in the literature.

## 6. Philological Convergences

### 6.1 Glyphic Style

A preliminary glyphic comparison based on published epigraphic drawings reveals a compatible letter morphology across the three corpora. In particular, the HE (𐤇) presents a three-horizontal-stroke form characteristic of ninth–eighth century BCE Aramaic in all three fragments, the LAMED (𐤋) shows the same swan-neck curve, and the interlinear spacing is regular and comparable. These preliminary observations must be confirmed by RTI analysis or by a specialist epigraphist with access to the original photographs.

### 6.2 The Central Structural Anomaly: Absence of the Author's Name

In all comparable Aramaic royal victory inscriptions — Zakkur (KAI 202), Mesha (KAI 181), Kilamuwa (KAI 24), Bar-Rakib (KAI 216) — the king names himself in the incipit or subscript. The absence of the author's name in Tel Dan constitutes a major structural anomaly without precedent in the genre. Neither fragment A (scribe 1, upper edge) nor fragment B (scribe 2, lower edge) contains the name Hazael.

This absence across both distinct scribes of the same stele is structurally difficult to explain—unless the name appears on a fragment not yet associated with the corpus. The Tell Afis fragment is that candidate.

## 7. Philological and Semantic Reconstruction — Three Sources

The following table presents a line-by-line reconstruction of the hypothetical complete inscription, rigorously distinguishing the three sources by color and indicating the certainty level of each restitution.

| Fragment A (blue)                          | Fragment B (green)                         | Tell Afis (orange) — hypothesis                |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Biran & Naveh 1993 · scribe 1 · upper edge | Biran & Naveh 1995 · scribe 2 · lower edge | Amadasi Guzzo 2009 · position to be determined |

| L.                                                                                                                       | Source         | Aramaic Transliteration                              | English Translation                                                  | Certainty                 |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>INCIPIT — Tell Afis Fragment TA.03.A.300 (Amadasi Guzzo 2009) — hypothetical position</b>                             |                |                                                      |                                                                      |                           |
| I                                                                                                                        | <b>Afis</b>    | ]nk · HZ' L · mlk · 'rm[                             | <i>I, Hazael, king of Aram</i>                                       | <b>MEDIUM</b>             |
| II                                                                                                                       | <b>Afis</b>    | [...] ]Q · D/R[ [...]                                | [...] {dynastic formula} [...]                                       | <b>WEAK</b>               |
| III                                                                                                                      | <b>Afis</b>    | [...] ]YHW(?)[ [...]                                 | [...] {theonym / anthroponym YHW-} [...]                             | <b>WEAK</b>               |
| IV                                                                                                                       | <b>Afis</b>    | [...] ]\$L · KL[ [...]                               | [...] {undetermined} [...]                                           | <b>WEAK</b>               |
| <b>MAIN BODY — Fragment A (Biran &amp; Naveh 1993) — upper edge · scribe 1 · straight-stroke bet (Langlois RTI 2024)</b> |                |                                                      |                                                                      |                           |
| 1                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | [']mr · '[ ] · wgzr[...]                             | [...] said [...] and cut [...]                                       | <b>STRONG (beginning)</b> |
| 2                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | [ ] · 'by · ysq[·'lwh·bh]tlh·mh · b'[...]            | <i>My father went up [against him, fought] in [...]</i>              | <b>STRONG (center)</b>    |
| 3                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | wyškb · 'by · yhk · 'l[·'bhw]h · wy'l · mlky[yšr' l] | <i>My father lay down, went to his [ancestors]. King of Is[rael]</i> | <b>STRONG</b>             |
| 4                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | r'l · qdm · b'r q · 'by[·w]hmlk · hdd · '[yty 'nh]   | <i>entered the land of my father. And Hadad made [me] king</i>       | <b>STRONG</b>             |

|                                                                                                                                           |                |                                                                 |                                                                                 |                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| 5                                                                                                                                         | <b>Frag. A</b> | 'nh · wyhk · hdd ·<br>qdmy[w]pq · mn · šb'[t<br>šby']           | me. And Hadad marched<br>before me. I went forth from<br>seven [campaigns]      | STRONG                |
| 6                                                                                                                                         | <b>Frag. A</b> | y · mlky · w'qtl · ml[kn·šb]n<br>· 'sry · '[lpy·rkb]            | of my kingdom. I killed<br>[seven]ty kings, [a thousand<br>char]iots            | STRONG                |
| 7                                                                                                                                         | <b>Frag. A</b> | kb · w'lpy · prš ·<br>[qtl·yt·yhw]rm · br · ['h'b<br>mlk yśr'l] | and a thousand horsemen. [I<br>killed Jeho]ram son [of Ahab,<br>king of Israel] | STRONG/MEDIUM         |
| 8                                                                                                                                         | <b>Frag. A</b> | mlk · yśr'l ·<br>wqtl[t·yt·'h'z]yhw ·<br>br[·yhwrm·mlk]         | king of Israel. And I kil[l]ed<br>Aha]ziah son [of Joram, king]                 | STRONG/MEDIUM         |
| 9                                                                                                                                         | <b>Frag. A</b> | k · bytdwd ·<br>w'šm[·yt·qryt·hm·h'rbt·w'hp<br>k·'ytn]          | of the House of David. And I<br>laid waste [their cities with the<br>sword...]  | STRONG                |
| 10                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | yt · 'rq · hm · l[yšmn ...]                                     | their land to [desolation...]                                                   | STRONG<br>(beginning) |
| 11                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | 'h'rn · wlh[...wyhw' · m]                                       | the other. And for him [...and<br>Jehu reigned]                                 | MEDIUM                |
| 12                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | lk · 'l · yś[r'l... w'šm · [...]                                | king over Is[rael...] And I laid<br>waste [...]                                 | MEDIUM                |
| 13                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. A</b> | mšr · '[l · kl h'rš]                                            | tribute upon [all the land]                                                     | STRONG<br>(beginning) |
| <b>LOWER EDGE — Fragment B / B1+B2 (Biran &amp; Naveh 1995) — scribe 2 · curved bet (Langlois RTI 2024) · lateral placement ABANDONED</b> |                |                                                                 |                                                                                 |                       |
| β1                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] mlky · [...]                                              | [...] my kings [...]                                                            | MEDIUM                |
| β2                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] w'qtl · ml[kn...]                                         | [...] and I killed the king[s...]                                               | MEDIUM                |
| β3                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] 'sry · '[lpy...]                                          | [...] a thousand [chariots...]                                                  | MEDIUM                |
| β4                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] yhw]rm · br[·'h'b...]                                     | [...] Jo]ram son [of Ahab...]                                                   | MEDIUM                |
| β5                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] 'h'z]yhw · br[·yhwrm...]                                  | [...] Aha]ziah son [of Joram...]                                                | MEDIUM                |
| β6                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] bytdwd · w'šm[...]                                        | [...] House of David. And I laid<br>waste [...]                                 | STRONG                |
| β7                                                                                                                                        | <b>Frag. B</b> | [...] wyhw' · mlk[...]                                          | [...] and Jehu reigned [over<br>Israel...]                                      | MEDIUM                |
| <b>CLOSING FORMULA — total lacuna in all three corpora · restitution by analogy (Zakkur, Mesha) · certainty WEAK</b>                      |                |                                                                 |                                                                                 |                       |

Table 4 — Three-color philological reconstruction. [ ] = attested lacuna · { } = conjectural restitution · plain text = attested.

## 7.1 Reconstructed Continuous Text — English Translation

**I, Hazael, king of Aram [...dynastic formula...]** *My father went up against him and fought in [the land of Israel]. My father lay down and went to his ancestors. And the king of Israel had previously entered the land of my father. And Hadad made me king, and Hadad marched before me. I went forth from seven [campaigns] of my kingdom. I killed [seven]ty kings, [a thousand chariots] and a thousand horsemen. [I killed Jeho]ram son [of Ahab king of Israel,] and I killed [Aha]ziah son*

*[of Joram king] of the House of David. And I laid waste [their cities with the sword,] their land to [desolation...] [— lacuna —] [...] and I killed the kings [...] a thousand [chariots...] Jo]ram son [of Ahab...] Aha]ziah son [of Joram...] House of David. And I laid waste [...] and Jehu reigned [over Israel...] [...closing formula / curse — total lacuna]*

## 8. Discussion and Limitations

### 8.1 Arguments in Favor of the Hypothesis

- Same material (polished black basalt), same documentary genre (Aramaic royal victory stele)
- Compatible glyphic style (preliminary analysis based on published drawings)
- Direct semantic complementarity: Tell Afis provides HZ'L+MLK, absent from both A and B
- Same discovery context (secondary position, reuse)
- The standard reconstruction (Biran & Naveh) has been abandoned by Langlois 2024 — the puzzle is fully reopened
- Three mobile pieces + one candidate fourth = a configuration consistent with a four-fragment stele in which the author's name is finally attested

### 8.2 Limitations and Objections

- Geographical distance of ~400 km between findspots — with no known explanation for this displacement.
- Absence of published comparative petrographic analysis (a gap to be filled)
- Available epigraphic drawings are insufficient to establish the mechanical interlocking of fracture profiles
- HZ'L est un HZ'L is an anthroponym attributed to several figures in the Aramaic corpus
- The Tell Afis fragment is held in Syria, the Tel Dan fragments in Jerusalem — physical comparison currently impossible for geopolitical reasons

### 2D image of fragments to be refined:

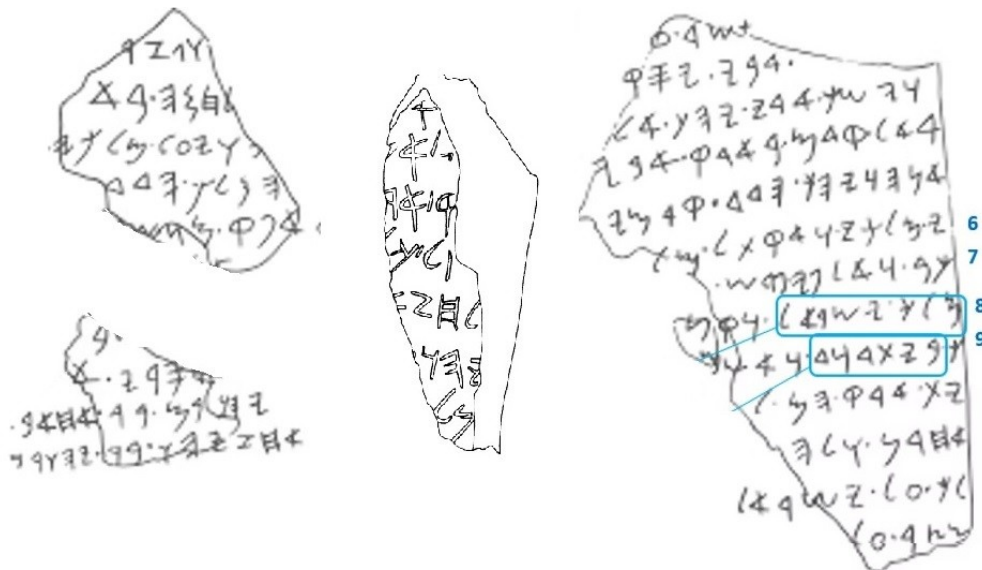


Figure 1 — Preliminary visual comparison of the fragments.

## 9. Conclusions and Research Programme

The present study demonstrates that the convergences between the Aramaic fragment from Tell Afis (TA.03.A.300) and the Tel Dan Stele are sufficiently numerous and structurally significant to warrant a thorough scientific investigation. Langlois's (2024) questioning of the Biran & Naveh reconstruction, by fully reopening the spatial puzzle of Tel Dan, strengthens the legitimacy of this approach.

We propose the following research programme:

- Comparative petrographic analysis (XRF or ICP-MS) of the basalts from all three fragments to determine whether their geochemical composition is consistent with a common origin
- 3D digitization of fracture profiles and digital comparison of contours — RTI method or 3D scanning
- Detailed epigraphic analysis of glyphs from original photographs — bet morphology in particular (scribe 1, scribe 2, Tell Afis)
- Revision of the Tel Dan spatial reconstruction integrating the Tell Afis fragment as a fourth candidate piece, in continuity with Langlois's work

The question is not resolved. It deserves to be asked.

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